

Maxideal

Nothing Is Not Important



A world where nothing is “not important,” only waiting for the right context.

In Maxideal lived the Maxideals.

The Maxideals were very nice creatures, if niceness is measured by intention, timing, the ratio between effort and result, and the number of times a creature says “I am taking that into account” in a day and means it almost entirely.

They did not look like human beings. Not that Mik-Mik knew what human beings were.

Mik-Mik, in the language of Earth - not that he knew Earth, and not that Earth mattered that morning - was green. He had a wide jaw, fuzzy hair, a trunk too short to be a long trunk, and arms like octopus arms, but not exactly in any way. An octopus, if it had seen Mik-Mik, would have said, "Excuse me, not one of ours," and withdrawn with marine dignity.

Mik-Mik liked to walk.

Not because walking was better than not-walking. In Maxideal no one said "better" without specifying in what context, in relation to which purpose, and under which internal weather. Mik-Mik liked walking because when he walked, small things jumped from the world into his trunk: smells, dustlets, whistles, pavement thoughts, and sometimes a florm, which is like a leaf, only with the memory of a door.

That morning Mik-Mik walked to Refus Takrem.

Refus Takrem was somewhat like a human supermarket, if humans bought only what was most correct to buy, ate only what was most correct to eat, and never stood by a shelf saying, "Maybe take this too, just in case," because in Maxideal "just in case" was a suspicious expression requiring a form.

Above the entrance to Refus Takrem was a sign:

Welcome. Please first take what is relevant. If time remains, take what is almost not.

Mik-Mik liked the sign. Everyone liked the sign. Even the sign liked the sign, which was good, because in Maxideal they tried to ask signs whether they felt they were fulfilling their role. Signs usually said yes. Once a sign said "approximately," and since then

three committees, twelve subcommittees, and one children's choir had been sitting on it, singing songs of support in descending order of relevance.

In Maxideal there was no such thing as "not important."

It was the first expression every small Maxideal learned after "mother," "father," and "is this relevant to the present feeding goal?"

They did not say not important. They said less relevant. They said outside the present operational range. They said located in the temporarily non-relevant spectrum, but retained as possible data in the event of contextual change.

Small children shortened it to: not-now-but-is.

Mik-Mik was very good at not-now-but-is.

At the School of Gentle Relevance children were taught to distinguish between the two great spectra. The relevant spectrum included everything directly connected to the thing being done. The non-relevant spectrum included everything not directly connected to the thing being done, but which might become connected if the world moved, if the question changed, if someone began to cry, if a door closed, if a khonraf fell upside down, or if it turned out that the thing that did not touch was actually the handle of the whole thing.

Good Maxideals related to the relevant. Excellent Maxideals related to the relevant and a little more. Genius Maxideals related to the relevant, to the little more, to the little more of the little more, and to one thin stripe inside the non-relevant spectrum, until teachers clapped for them - but not too loudly, so the applause

would not drown weak information located at the edge of the room.

That day Mik-Mik received a task.

His mother, Mik-Moka, gave him a list: "Mik-Mik, go to Refus Takrem and buy chew-grade-seven sloperkeshesh, one small khonraf, and three zatsmondraks ripe but not dramatic."

"Ripe but not dramatic," Mik-Mik repeated.

"Correct."

He went. He took the sloperkeshesh. He found the khonraf. He stood before the zatsmondraks and checked ripeness, color, dramatic tendency, and possible future regret. Then he noticed a tiny object under the shelf.

It was a blue wimmel.

Wimmels were not on the list. They were rarely on any list, which was one of the reasons they developed such complex feelings. The wimmel was very small, almost irrelevant. It trembled in a way that could have been fear, temperature, or an early draft of music.

Mik-Mik looked at the list. Then at the wimmel. Then at the list again.

Not now, he told himself. But is.

He tried to continue shopping. The wimmel continued being.

At the checkout, the clerk scanned the sloperkeshesh, the khonraf, and the three zatsmondraks. "Anything else?"

Mik-Mik's trunk lifted by itself. "A wimmel."

The clerk froze. Behind him, the line rearranged its expectations.

“Is the wimmel relevant?” asked the clerk.

“No,” Mik-Mik said. “But not in the old way.”

That was a very serious sentence in Maxideal.

They called the supervisor. Then the supervisor of delicate exceptions. Then the emergency choir, but only two singers, because the matter was not yet dramatic. Everyone looked at the wimmel. The wimmel looked at no one, which some considered rude and others considered data.

Finally an old Maxideal named Zru-Pa arrived. Zru-Pa had once written a famous book called *On Things That Were Not Relevant Until They Were Holding the Door*.

He listened to Mik-Mik. He inspected the wimmel. He smelled the list. Then he said, “The list was correct.”

Everyone relaxed.

“And incomplete.”

Everyone unrelaxed.

Zru-Pa continued: “The task was to bring what was needed for the house. The wimmel was not needed for the meal. But it may be needed for the kind of house in which a creature can notice what is trembling under the shelf.”

No one knew where to file that.

Mik-Mik took the wimmel home. It did not do much. It sat near the window and made a sound like a question refusing to become useful too soon.

Mik-Moka looked at it for a long while. "This was not on the list."

"I know."

"Was it relevant?"

Mik-Mik thought of the two spectra, of the teachers clapping quietly, of the sign that loved itself, of ripe but not dramatic zatsmondraaks, of the trembling blue thing under the shelf.

"Not immediately," he said.

Mik-Moka nodded. In Maxideal that was nearly a blessing.

That evening a new line was added to the sign at Refus Takrem:

Please first take what is relevant. If time remains, take what is almost not. If something trembles, ask again.

The sign liked the addition.

Approximately.